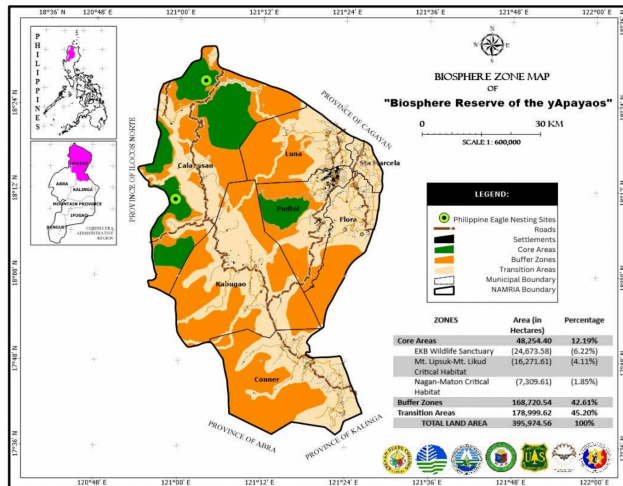


Small Grant Proposal

I. Project Location

A. Biophysical Profile



The project will be implemented in the province of Apayao, which is characterized by diverse forest ecosystems including mossy, montane, upper and lowland dipterocarp, mixed dipterocarp, ultramafic, and karst forests. Apayao's freshwater ecosystem is also of notable significance. Around 75 percent of the province is drained by Apayao River, a 180-kilometer-long waterway and the largest water body in the province. The river forms part of the Apayao-Abulug River Basin, which

has a total area of 278,651 hectares, making it the 6th largest river basin in the country. The Apayao-Abulug River Basin and other freshwater ecosystems in the province serve as critical habitats for aquatic biodiversity and provide irrigation and water supply for agriculture and domestic use. In addition to regulating floods and maintaining soil fertility, the river basin also supports the ways of life and livelihoods of many Indigenous communities.

Importantly, Apayao has at least five known Philippine Eagle territories that are perfect candidates for Critical Habitat declaration and management, since none of these fall within existing protected areas. Apayao currently has no pre-existing protected area declaration under national law, aside from traditional Indigenous Protected Areas that have not been formally affirmed by any national legislation. Moreover, based on the latest Species Distribution Modelling for the Philippine Eagle, there could be additional eagle pairs present across the reserve. Apayao also has a natural forest cover of about 346,000 hectares, representing 88% of its total land area (Global Forest Watch). With this level of intact forest, Apayao holds the record for having one of the largest natural forest covers in the country. These forests are not only vast but also harbor an extraordinary wealth of forest biodiversity and ecosystem dynamics, including threatened species like the Philippine Eagle, hornbills, and other forest-dependent wildlife. This biodiversity underscores the global significance of Apayao's forests as reservoirs of unique life forms and ecological processes.

However, for any attempt to set aside forest habitats either as National Protected Areas or as Other Effective Conservation Measures (OECMs), such initiatives should be underpinned by sound scientific knowledge, drawing from both western science and Indigenous/Local Knowledge Systems (ILKS). Although not as popular as biodiversity or natural sciences, scientific information on forest governance systems is equally, if not more, important, particularly in the context of overlapping values and tenure over forests and other natural habitats.

B. Socioeconomic Profile

The province has a population of 124,366 as of the 2020 PSA survey, with 25.83% of residents living in urban settlements. Economic activities within the province include agriculture, small-scale fisheries and emerging eco-tourism. Culturally, Apayao is home to 14 ethnic tribes, nearly half of which (49.96%) belong to the Isnag group, while other cultural minorities include the Ibanags, Malauegs, Kankanaey, Bago, Ibaloi, Kalingas, Tingguians, Agtas, Itawes, and Ifugaos. The project's primary target groups include local researchers within the province, as well as students, faculty, and local government officials, particularly those affiliated with Apayao State College, who will benefit from capacity-building initiatives in research. These groups were selected to support the objectives of the research summit, which seeks to synthesize studies conducted in Apayao from 2020 to 2025 and co-develop a five-year research agenda through a combination of research review, keynote presentations, and focus group discussions.

C. Governance

The Biosphere Reserve of the yApayaos (BRyA) is governed by the BRyA Council under the BRyA Management Plan. Local mechanisms such as Provincial Ordinance No. 01-2013 and Calanasan Municipal Ordinance No. 12-2012 institutionalize the indigenous *lapat* system of environmental management. Proposed conservation sites include the EKB and Agora Wildlife Sanctuaries and critical habitats in Nagan-Maton, Cagandungan-Calabigan, and Mt. Lipsuk–Mt. Likod. The landscape also covers the Apayao-Abulug Watershed and ancestral domains of the Isnags in Pudtol, Calanasan, and Kabugao, supported by ADSDPPs of the Ingajan Isnag ICC (Pudtol) and Zumigui-Bayugao Agta ICC (Luna).

II. Rationale and Objectives

Problem Statement

Apayao ecosystems face habitat loss from agricultural expansion, timber poaching, unsustainable harvesting, and poor waste practices. The uncontrolled population growth, poverty, unregulated *kaingin* or slash-and-burn agriculture, timber poaching, and improper waste disposal have reduced the forest cover within the province. With the growing human demand for land, timber, and natural resources in a young province whose population is steadily increasing, putting in place locally appropriate and nested forest/resource governance systems becomes critical. Such systems must recognize the nature of Apayao's forest ecosystems as Social-Ecological Systems (SES). But these governance systems must be grounded in the best available scientific knowledge, which in turn should be collected with a clear orientation toward informing policy reform, governance strengthening, and adaptive management. The breadth of research topics proposed during this research summit should therefore be framed through the lens of the SES framework, ensuring that science, policy, and Indigenous stewardship are tightly interwoven in the conservation of the forest biodiversity and sustainability of the Biosphere Reserve of the yApayaos.

Project Goal

To ensure alignment of academic contributions with the reserve's needs, this conference aims to review recent research outputs from higher education institutions and co-create a forward-looking research agenda responsive to the biocultural context and governance priorities of the biosphere reserve, with strong emphasis on forest biodiversity, ecosystem dynamics, resource governance systems, and geospatial mapping and analyses. As a globally recognized site under UNESCO's Man and the Biosphere (MAB) Programme for integrating biodiversity conservation, sustainable development, and cultural resilience, it is essential that governance and management of the reserve be informed by a robust, interdisciplinary, and Indigenous knowledge-grounded research agenda.

The overall goal of the research summit is to strengthen multi-stakeholder engagement and partnerships among stakeholders of the Biosphere Reserve of the yApayao (BRyA) by establishing a robust, interdisciplinary, and Indigenous knowledge-grounded research agenda for the years 2026 to 2031.

Through the research summit, partnership commitments will be made to ensure that the governance and management of the BRyA is anchored in a sound, inclusive, science and culture-based knowledge base. By aligning with the BRyA Management Plan and contributing to OECM recognition, the Summit ensures that outcomes are relevant both to local governance and to national and international conservation frameworks.

Project Objectives

1. Synthesize and document at least five years' worth of academic and institutional research (2020–2025) on Apayao across different research themes (Biodiversity Research and Conservation, Land Use and Natural Resource Management, Climate Change and Ecosystem Resilience, Socio-Cultural Systems and Indigenous Knowledge Practices)
2. Assess the alignment of existing research with the core functions of a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve through plenary and thematic panel discussions.
3. Co-develop, adopt, and establish partnership commitments for a Five-Year Research Agenda (2026–2031) that identifies priority topics and strategies that guides the creation of policies and sets the direction of resource and land use management in the Provincial and Municipal Local Government Units, the DENR, NCIP, and Provincial Tourism Office.
4. Facilitate the formation of at least five formalized partnership commitments among stakeholders to support the implementation of the research agenda and the establishment of the provincial research center.
5. Produce and disseminate a consolidated research review report, a five-year research agenda document, a policy brief, and a consolidated research database and directory to stakeholders at least three months after the summit.
6. Facilitate and contribute to the advancement of the research capacity of Apayao-based academic and research institutions, and encourage knowledge sharing among stakeholders that contributes to the research value of the Biosphere Reserve of the yApayaos.

III. Expected Results per Objective

1. Research review synthesizing at least 30 studies over the past five years (2020–2025)
2. Report mapping research against UNESCO Biosphere Reserve functions with inputs from stakeholders
3. Five-Year Research Agenda (2026–2031) with guiding questions and thematic priorities
4. At least 5 signed partnership commitments (MOUs) and consolidated report for research recommendations
5. Disseminate digital and printed copies of the research review report, five-year research agenda, policy brief, research database and directory, and summit proceedings to at least 15 stakeholders (government, academe, CSOs, and international partners)

IV. Strategies to achieve results

1. Compile studies from HEIs, research agencies, and LGUs into a research review with annotated bibliography and thematic synthesis for presentation during the summit.
2. Conduct panel discussions with researchers, Indigenous leaders, LGUs, DENR, and CSOs to assess research alignment with the three functions of a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve consolidated into a mapping report.
3. Hold breakout workshops to co-develop a Five-Year Research Agenda, including priority topics, guiding questions, and strategies to be refined and adopted in plenary.
4. Facilitate and sign at least five partnership commitments among Indigenous communities, academic institutions, government, and CSOs. Agreements and working group membership will be presented during the closing session.
5. Within three months, produce and distribute the Research Review Report, Five-Year Research Agenda, and Policy Brief/Proceedings to at least 15 institutions.

VI. Institutionalization and Sustainability Mechanisms

The activities initiated by the research summit will be sustained through the formal adoption of the Five-Year Research Agenda (2026–2031) by the Provincial Government of Apayao, local government units, state universities and colleges, and relevant national government agencies. This agenda will serve as a guiding framework for formulating provincial and local ordinances and policies, as well as for mobilizing institutional and external funding support. It will also provide the basis for implementing programs, projects, and activities prescribed under the BRyA Management Plan. The partnership commitments and multi-stakeholder working group established during the summit will ensure continued coordination, monitoring, and advocacy beyond the project period. Knowledge products will be disseminated widely to government stakeholders for integration to development plans and programs. By embedding the research agenda into existing institutional frameworks and leveraging UNESCO and development partner networks, the outcomes of the summit will be sustained and expanded over time.

VII. Attachments

Organization Bylaws, Organizational Chart, Financial Statement, Certificate of Registration, CSO Accreditation

Important note: Please provide the source or reference of information cited in the proposal.

Please answer:

[How did you find out PTFCF Call for proposals? Philippine Eagle Foundation]